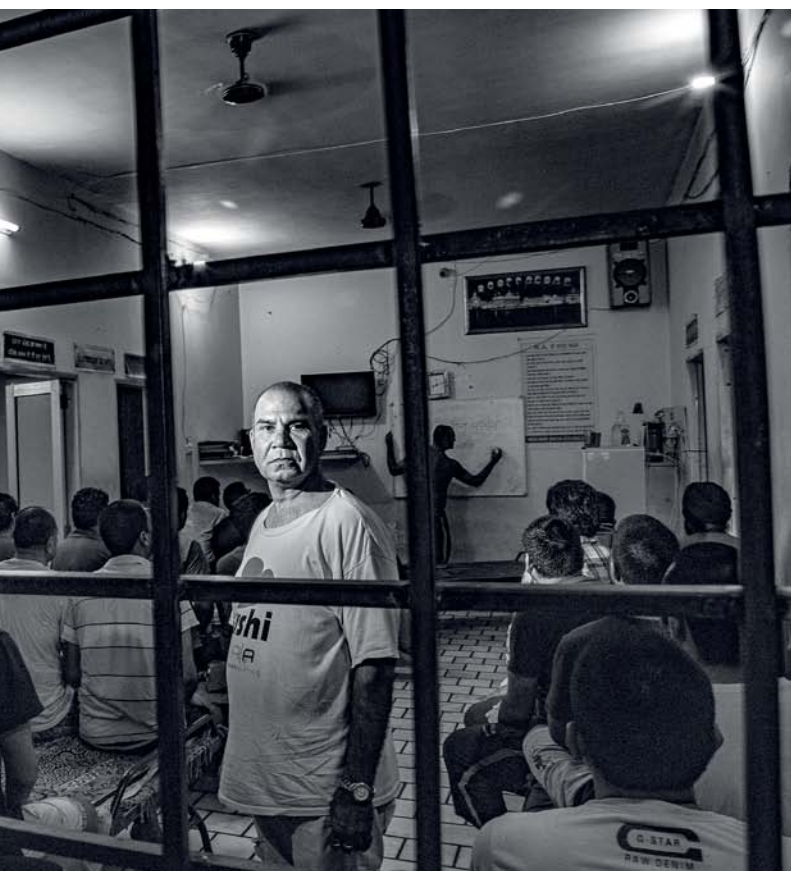
stress. "Very often," Murthy says, "it starts with a broken relationship, not doing well in their academic life, loneliness or coming from a very disturbed background."

Ambekar is on the same page with Murthy on the issue. "Would you press criminal action against someone who has chronic diabetes if they have an extra gulab jamun?" he asks. Drug abuse, he says, is similar to those suffering from hypertension and other non-communicable diseases. "It has to be treated, not criminalised." Ambekar cites the example of Portugal, which is one of the countries that has been able to successfully decriminalise drugs. As far back as 2001, the country initiated legal reform, according to which anyone caught taking illicit drugs would be taken to rehabilitation centres and counselled to give up drug consumption. That has not only seen the rate of illegal drug use drop in Portugal but also helped it be better off than many European countries that still have drug abuse on their criminal statutes. Apart from decriminalising consumption per se, Ambekar says "the government [of Portugal] also invested adequately in prevention and treatment measures and improved health and welfare support. It is because of our poor public health response that the entire drug control system has been hijacked by law enforcing authorities and public health has taken a back seat."



"Youngsters should be made aware of the harm drugs cause for them to make informed decisions and know the results of their actions"

RADHIKA CHAKRAVARTHY
Joint Secretary, Ministry of Social Justice



BANDEEP SINGH

A HEALING TOUCH

Among the solutions to bring down drug consumption, experts propose working on demand reduction, which includes treatment, rehabilitation and awareness strategies to dissuade people from taking drugs. Radhika Chakravarthy, joint secretary in the social justice and empowerment ministry, says, "Youngsters should be made aware of the harm caused by drug abuse so that they can make an informed decision and are aware of the consequences of their actions." The ministry had in 2020 launched a 'Nasha Mukti Abhiyan', an awareness generation programme directed at women and youth, whose aim was to sensitise people to the reasons why drug dependency grows—without stigmatising users. The campaign has already reached out to 25 million people, though the Covid pandemic did disrupt their work for a while. The ministry has also set up treatment centres in 272 hotspot districts and gets rehabilitated drug addicts to counsel those abusing drugs the way Narcotics Anonymous does. The ministry is also pushing for a graded decriminalising of drugs consumption under the NDPS Act.

Ambekar suggests two kinds of awareness programmes as the way forward. One, which lays emphasis on how drugs are not good for you, and another that offers hope to drug addicts and tells them that it is possible to come out of their addiction. The huge advances in synthetic drugs and less harmful replacements can help addicts. He cites the example of Punjab where such replacement drugs were made available on a large scale in clinics across the state, which made a huge difference. The state's model can easily be replicated on a national scale. Also, in addition to specialised clinics for treatment, general hospitals too can be persuaded to set up basic treatment facilities. "It is something that is easily doable," says Ambekar, "doesn't require huge resources or research and has also conclusively shown that it costs much less to treat people than putting them in jail. It is a win-win situation. We should decriminalise usage to enable our youth to come forward for treatment, which they may not be doing presently out of fear." Asserting that no one strategy will work, Murthy recommends multiple approaches. These include renormalising drug use in the community, working on reducing the demand for drugs, identifying people early for treatment and ensuring such treatment is up to standard. There are no shortcuts, Murthy says, everyone has to put their shoulder to the wheel. It's advice well worth heeding. ■